SAMPLE

Honoring Covenants: The Bond of Trust

'Ahd (عهد) in the Quran

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Free sample: Introduction & Chapter 1

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This free sample contains the Introduction and Chapter 1. The complete book contains the full contents above.

Introduction: The Sacred Weight of a Promise

A covenant — 'ahd in Arabic — is not merely a promise. It is a bond. It is the sacred tie that connects one person to another, one community to another, and the human being to the divine. The Quran treats covenants with a weight that exceeds any modern legal conception of contract. A covenant in the Quran is a spiritual reality — a commitment that carries the authority of the One who witnesses it, the gravity of the One who commands it, and the accountability of the Day when all covenants will be examined.

The Quran commands the fulfillment of covenants in some of its most emphatic language. "And fulfill the covenant of Allah when you have taken it"

(16:91). "And fulfill the promise — indeed, the promise will be questioned" (17:34). "And those who are to their trusts and promises attentive" (23:8). The command appears in multiple surahs, in multiple contexts, with varying degrees of detail — but always with the same urgency. The fulfillment of covenants is not optional; it is not conditional; it is not negotiable. It is a divine command that the Quran places alongside the worship of Allah and the kindness to parents.

This book — the fourth in the Commands & Prohibitions sub-series — explores the Quranic vision of honoring covenants. It examines the foundational verses, the divine model (Allah as the keeper of covenants), the primordial covenant between Allah and humanity (the Covenant of Alast), the covenants between people (trusts, treaties, contracts), the prophetic models of covenant-keeping, the anatomy of covenant-breaking (hypocrisy and betrayal), the specific case of covenants with non-Muslims, the prohibitions related to covenants, and the spiritual reward for those who keep their bonds.

The Quran's treatment of covenants is comprehensive because covenants are everywhere. Every promise is a covenant. Every contract is a covenant. Every treaty is a covenant. Every marriage is a covenant. Every oath is a covenant. The person who honors all of these — from the largest treaty to the smallest promise — has fulfilled the Quranic command. The person who treats any of these lightly has fallen short. The Quran does not distinguish between great and small covenants; it demands faithfulness at every level, because the God who witnesses the treaty also witnesses the everyday promise, and the God who commands the fulfillment of contracts also commands the fulfillment of casual commitments.

The first chapter begins with the foundational command — the verse that establishes the fulfillment of covenants as a divine decree, paired with the prohibition of oath-breaking, and framed with the remembrance of Allah as the

guarantor of every bond.

Chapter 1: The Command — Fulfilling the Covenant of Allah

And fulfill the covenant of Allah when you have taken it, and do not break oaths after their confirmation while you have made Allah your guarantor. Indeed, Allah knows what you do. (16:91)

This verse is the foundational command regarding the honoring of covenants.

It contains three elements: a positive command ("fulfill the covenant"), a

negative prohibition ("do not break oaths"), and a theological grounding ("you have made Allah your guarantor"). The three elements together form a complete moral framework: you are commanded to keep your covenants, you are prohibited from breaking them, and the reason for both is that Allah Himself is the witness and guarantor of every covenant you make.

The word 'ahd — covenant — comes from a root meaning to bind, to fasten, to guard. A covenant is a bond — something that ties two parties together in a relationship of obligation. The Quran uses 'ahd for the covenant between Allah and humanity, the covenant between Allah and the prophets, the covenants between individuals (marriage, contracts, promises), and the covenants between nations (treaties, alliances). The breadth of usage reveals that the Quran sees covenants as a universal feature of moral life — the means by which trust is established, obligations are defined, and relationships are sustained.

The command "fulfill the covenant of Allah" is absolute. It does not say "fulfill the convenient covenants" or "fulfill the covenants that are easy." It says: fulfill the covenant of Allah — any covenant, every covenant, all covenants. The phrase "the covenant of Allah" does not mean only covenants made directly with Allah (such as the Covenant of Alast, discussed in Chapter 3). It means every covenant, because every covenant — even one between two people — is made with Allah as the witness. The covenant between buyer and seller is "the covenant of Allah" because Allah is the guarantor. The covenant between husband and wife is "the covenant of Allah" because Allah is the witness. The elevation of every covenant to "the covenant of Allah" means that no covenant is merely human — all covenants carry a divine dimension.

The verse then prohibits the breaking of oaths: "do not break oaths after their confirmation." The word tawthiq — confirmation — means that the oath has

been solidified, made firm, established. The prohibition applies to oaths that have been confirmed — not casual remarks, not tentative commitments, but

solemn promises that have been formalized. The prohibition is specific: after you have confirmed an oath, you may not break it. The confirmation creates the bond; the breaking of the bond is the sin.

The verse adds a phrase of extraordinary depth: "while you have made Allah your guarantor" (wa qad ja'altum Allaha 'alaykum wakeelan). When two people make a covenant, they invoke Allah as their witness — they call upon Him to guarantee the bond. This invocation, whether explicit or implicit, transforms the covenant from a human agreement into a divine trust. The person who

breaks the covenant has not merely wronged the other party; they have betrayed the trust of Allah, who was called upon as the guarantor.

The command is repeated in 17:34: "And fulfill the promise — indeed, the promise will be questioned" (wa awfu bil-'ahdi inna al-'ahda kana mas'ulan). The word mas'ul — questioned — means that the promise will be examined on the Day of Judgment. The fulfillment or breaking of every promise will be reviewed. No promise is too small to be questioned; no covenant is too large to be overlooked. The verse establishes the accountability of covenants: they are not forgotten when they are broken, and they are not ignored when they are kept. Every covenant is on the record.

In 23:8, the Quran describes the believers as "those who are to their trusts and promises attentive" — wa alladhina hum li-amanatihim wa 'ahdihim ra'un. The word ra'un means attentive, watchful, careful. The believers are described as people who watch over their trusts and promises — not people who make promises carelessly and break them casually, but people who are attentive to every commitment, who guard every bond, who treat every covenant as a sacred trust. This quality is listed among the defining characteristics of those who will inherit Firdaws (23:10-11). The fulfillment of covenants is not merely a virtue; it is a condition of paradise.

In 2:177, the verse that defines righteousness (birr), the Quran includes "those who fulfill their promise when they promise" among the qualities of the righteous. The list includes belief, prayer, charity, promise-keeping, and patience. The inclusion of promise-keeping in this comprehensive definition of righteousness reveals its centrality in the Quranic moral vision. The person who prays but breaks promises has a defect in their prayer. The person who gives charity but violates contracts has a defect in their charity. The fulfillment of covenants is woven into the fabric of righteousness — not an isolated virtue but a thread in the larger weave.

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